CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The European Union and the Politics of Denial

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Scholars of European antisemitism often puzzle over the factors that explain its persistence while rarely investigating the effectiveness of the European Union's (EU's) stated efforts to ameliorate it. Antisemitism's recent resurgence (and increasing convergence with anti-Zionism) throughout the region since 9/11 provides a fitting moment to reflect on how the EU has chosen to respond.

Although the EU insists that it "takes every opportunity to condemn racism, xenophobia, antisemitism and other related intolerance,"[1] one cannot assume that its condemnations render (Europe's) Jews less vulnerable to prejudice. Indeed, the underlying reality may be that the polity's pronouncements, reports and legislation on antisemitism conceal a dangerous reluctance to forcefully and consistently confront it.

Consider the public statement issued by Catherine Ashton to commemorate International Holocaust Memorial Day in 2014. Representing the EU in her capacity as the polity's first High Representative for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy she wrote,

> On Holocaust Remembrance Day, we must keep alive the memory of this tragedy. It is an occasion to remind us all of the need to continue fighting prejudice and racism in our own time. We must remain vigilant against the dangers of hate speech and redouble our commitment to prevent any form of intolerance. The respect of human rights and diversity lies at the heart of what the European Union stands for.[2]

In substituting platitudinous references to racism, intolerance and human rights for antisemitism's centrality to the Holocaust, Ashton managed to withdraw Jewish genocide from a catalogue of Nazi infamy. That she accomplished this through an international Holocaust commemoration statement under the guise of promoting "human rights" offers an ironic victory to the assassins of memory, regardless of her intent.

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Anti-Judaism, Antisemitism, and Delegitimizing Israel, Nebraska, 2016. ProQuest Ebook Central,